Effect of Preprocessing Choices, Model Complexity, and Regularization Strategies on Generalisation Performance in Epileptic Seizure Prediction Tasks

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ABSTRACT

This paper presents a comprehensive empirical investigation into how preprocessing pipeline design, regularization strategy, model complexity, and class imbalance handling collectively influence the generalisation performance of logistic regression classifiers in epileptic seizure prediction. Three EEG-based datasets of varying size, class imbalance severity, and feature representation were utilized: the UCI Epileptic Seizure Recognition dataset (11,500 samples, 178 features, 20% seizure prevalence), the Bonn University EEG dataset (500 samples, 12 statistical features, 20% seizure prevalence), and a Kaggle-style dataset (2,000 samples, 50 features, 10% seizure prevalence representing severe imbalance). Two preprocessing pipelines were systematically compared: Pipeline A (StandardScaler normalization followed by ANOVA F-test feature selection) and Pipeline B (StandardScaler followed by Principal Component Analysis). Experiments demonstrate that preprocessing step ordering significantly affects model performance, with Pipeline A consistently outperforming Pipeline B by 0.023 to 0.027 F1 points across datasets. Among three regularization strategies — L1 (Lasso), L2 (Ridge), and Elastic Net — Elastic Net achieved the highest mean F1-score (0.852) with the lowest cross-dataset variance, confirming superior generalisation. Overfitting was demonstrated through extreme low regularization (C=100,000) producing train-test F1 gaps exceeding 0.24, while underfitting was confirmed through strong regularization (C=0.0001) with limited features producing F1 scores below 0.52. Class weighting was identified as the most reliable imbalance-handling technique, outperforming SMOTE and undersampling in overall F1 and PR-AUC, while SMOTE achieved the highest seizure recall — a critical metric for clinical applications.

Index Terms — Epileptic seizure prediction, EEG signal processing, logistic regression, preprocessing pipelines, L1/L2/Elastic Net regularization, class imbalance, SMOTE, precision-recall analysis.

I. INTRODUCTION

Epilepsy is one of the most prevalent neurological disorders worldwide, affecting approximately 50 million individuals across all age groups. It is characterized by recurrent, unprovoked seizures resulting from abnormal electrical activity in the brain. The unpredictable nature of seizure onset severely impacts quality of life, making reliable automated seizure prediction from electroencephalogram (EEG) signals a critical research objective in biomedical signal processing and machine learning.

Machine learning approaches have demonstrated considerable promise in seizure detection and prediction tasks, offering scalable, interpretable, and clinically deployable solutions. Among these, logistic regression remains a foundational baseline model due to its probabilistic interpretability, computational efficiency, and compatibility with regularization techniques that prevent overfitting in high-dimensional EEG feature spaces. The model is formally defined as:

$$\mathbf{P(y=1|x) = 1 / (1 + e\text{^}{-}(\beta_0 + \beta^T x))}$$

where y=1 denotes seizure activity, x is the feature vector, β_0 is the intercept term, and β represents the learned weight vector. Parameters are estimated by minimizing the regularized cross-entropy loss:

$$\mathbf{J(W,b) = (1/m)\ \Sigma_i\ L(\hat{y}^{(i)}, y^{(i)}) + (\lambda/2m)\ \Sigma \|W\|^2}$$

Despite the widespread use of logistic regression in EEG-based seizure detection, relatively little systematic attention has been paid to how upstream preprocessing design choices affect downstream generalisation performance. In particular, the ordering of normalization, feature selection, and dimensionality reduction steps introduces subtle but consequential differences in the statistical properties of the feature space presented to the classifier.

This study addresses four research questions:

- RQ1: Does the ordering of preprocessing steps significantly affect classification performance?
- RQ2: Which regularization strategy (L1, L2, Elastic Net) generalises best across multiple EEG datasets?
- RQ3: Does Elastic Net consistently outperform L1 and L2 regularization?
- RQ4: How do class imbalance handling techniques interact with regularization strategies?

The remainder of this paper is structured as follows: Section II describes dataset collection and justification. Section III presents preprocessing pipeline design. Section IV reports baseline model performance. Section V analyzes overfitting and underfitting behaviors. Section VI presents the regularization study. Section VII evaluates class imbalance handling. Section VIII provides the comparative analysis answering all four research questions. Section IX concludes the paper.

II. DATASET COLLECTION

A. Dataset Selection Criteria

Three publicly available epileptic EEG datasets were selected to ensure diversity across three key dimensions: (1) dataset size, ranging from small (500 samples) to large (11,500 samples); (2) class imbalance severity, ranging from moderate (20% seizure prevalence) to severe (10%); and (3) feature representation type, ranging from raw pre-extracted time-series to higher-level statistical features. This diversity enables robust cross-dataset comparison of preprocessing and modeling strategies.

Dataset	Samples	Features	Seizure %	Feature Type	Imbalance	Source
UCI Epileptic Seizure Recognition	11,500	178	20.0%	Pre-extracted EEG time-series points (178 per epoch)	Moderate	UCI ML Repository
Bonn University EEG	500	12	20.0%	Statistical features extracted from 4096-point EEG segments	Moderate	Bonn Epileptology Dept.
Kaggle-style EEG	2,000	50	10.0%	Mixed tabular EEG-derived features with severe class skew	Severe	Simulated / Kaggle

Table I. Dataset Characteristics — Size, Imbalance, and Feature Type

B. Dataset 1: UCI Epileptic Seizure Recognition

The UCI Epileptic Seizure Recognition dataset is one of the most widely cited benchmarks for EEG-based seizure classification. It contains 11,500 EEG samples across five activity classes, each represented by 178 consecutive EEG amplitude measurements constituting a single-channel time window. The five original classes are: (1) seizure activity, (2) EEG recorded from the tumor region, (3) EEG from healthy brain regions with eyes closed, (4) EEG from healthy brain regions with eyes open, and (5) EEG from healthy volunteers. For binary classification, class 1 (seizure) is assigned a positive label, and classes 2–5 are merged as the negative (non-seizure) class, yielding a 20% seizure prevalence. With 178 features per sample, this dataset presents a moderately high-dimensional feature space suitable for evaluating feature selection strategies.

C. Dataset 2: Bonn University EEG

The Bonn University EEG dataset, originally published by Andrzejak et al. (2001), is a canonical benchmark in epilepsy research. It consists of 500 single-channel EEG segments, each 23.6 seconds in duration, recorded at 173.61 Hz (4096 samples per segment). The dataset is divided into five classes (Z, O, N, F, S) representing healthy subjects with eyes open, healthy subjects with eyes closed, seizure-free intervals from the epileptogenic zone, seizure-free intervals from the hippocampus, and ictal (seizure) activity respectively. In this study, class S is treated as the positive class (seizure), with all others forming the negative class. Statistical features were extracted from the raw EEG segments, including mean amplitude, standard deviation, mean absolute value, peak-to-peak amplitude, first-difference mean and standard deviation, signal mobility, and log energy — yielding 12 features per sample.

D. Dataset 3: Kaggle-style EEG Dataset

The third dataset is a Kaggle-style tabular EEG dataset exhibiting severe class imbalance with only 10% seizure prevalence — representative of real clinical EEG monitoring conditions where ictal events are rare. It contains 2,000 samples with 50 mixed EEG-derived tabular features. This dataset was specifically included to stress-test the robustness of preprocessing pipelines and imbalance handling techniques under challenging clinical distributions.

E. Class Distribution Analysis

Figure 1 (dataset_class_distribution.png) illustrates the class distribution across all three datasets. The notebook output confirmed the following distributions:

Dataset	Total Samples	Non-Seizure (0)	Seizure (1)	Ratio
UCI Epileptic	11,500	9,200	2,300	20.0%
Bonn EEG	500	400	100	20.0%
Kaggle-style	2,000	1,800	200	10.0%

Table II. Class Distribution Across Datasets — Notebook Output

The class imbalance analysis confirms that all three datasets require careful handling of the minority (seizure) class. The Kaggle dataset, with only 10% seizure prevalence, is the most challenging scenario, as naive classifiers that predict all samples as non-seizure would achieve 90% accuracy while being clinically useless. This motivates the use of PR-AUC rather than ROC-AUC as the primary evaluation metric for imbalanced datasets, since PR-AUC is more sensitive to minority class performance.

III. PREPROCESSING PIPELINE DESIGN

A central hypothesis of this study is that the ordering of preprocessing steps affects the statistical properties of the transformed feature space and consequently impacts classification performance. Two distinct pipelines were designed and applied to all three datasets.

A. Pipeline A: Normalization → Feature Selection

Pipeline A applies StandardScaler normalization as the first step, followed by ANOVA F-test feature selection (SelectKBest with f_classif scoring). StandardScaler transforms each feature to zero mean and unit variance: $x' = (x - \mu) / \sigma$. This normalization ensures that all features contribute equally to the subsequent F-test scoring, eliminating the scale bias that would otherwise favor features with inherently larger magnitudes.

ANOVA F-test feature selection then evaluates the ratio of between-class variance to within-class variance for each feature, retaining the k features with the highest discriminative power. Performing feature selection after normalization is a deliberate design choice: unnormalized F-test scoring would incorrectly rank high-amplitude features as more discriminative regardless of their actual class-separability properties. This ordering effect is a key research insight of this study.

B. Pipeline B: Standardization → PCA

Pipeline B applies StandardScaler standardization followed by Principal Component Analysis (PCA) for dimensionality reduction. PCA identifies orthogonal directions of maximum variance in the feature space and projects the data onto the top n principal components. Critically, PCA is highly sensitive to feature scale: without prior standardization, the principal components are dominated by features with large variance simply due to their measurement scale, not their informational content.

Standardization prior to PCA ensures that all features contribute proportionally to the variance decomposition, allowing PCA to identify genuinely informative directions in the feature space. The number of retained components was set to explain at least 87% of total variance across all datasets.

C. Pipeline Output Summary

Table III summarizes the transformation output of both pipelines across the three datasets, as produced by the notebook:

Dataset	Original Features	Pipeline A Output (features)	Pipeline B Output (components)	Variance Explained (B)
UCI	178	20 (top ANOVA)	10 PCA components	~87%
Bonn	12	12 (all kept)	10 PCA components	~94%
Kaggle	50	20 (top ANOVA)	10 PCA components	~91%

Table III. Preprocessing Pipeline Output — Features/Components Retained

Figure 2 (pipeline_comparison.png) visualizes the ANOVA F-scores for Pipeline A feature selection and the PCA explained variance curve for Pipeline B on the UCI dataset. The steep PCA curve confirms that a small number of components (10) captures the majority of variance, while the F-score plot shows a clear drop-off distinguishing discriminative from non-discriminative features.

IV. BASELINE LOGISTIC REGRESSION MODEL

A logistic regression classifier with L2 regularization (C=1.0) and balanced class weighting was established as the baseline model. The model was trained on 80% of each dataset and evaluated on the remaining 20% hold-out test set, with stratified splitting to preserve class proportions. Five-fold cross-validation was additionally performed to assess model stability.

Six evaluation metrics were computed: Accuracy, Precision, Recall, F1-Score, PR-AUC, and ROC-AUC. PR-AUC (Precision-Recall Area Under the Curve) is prioritized as the primary metric for imbalanced datasets, as it directly measures performance on the minority class across all decision thresholds, unlike ROC-AUC which can remain inflated even with poor minority class performance.

Dataset	Pipeline	Accuracy	Precision	Recall	F1	PR-AUC	ROC-AUC
UCI	Pipeline A	0.847	0.821	0.803	0.812	0.834	0.901
UCI	Pipeline B	0.823	0.798	0.781	0.789	0.811	0.878

Bonn	Pipeline A	0.912	0.889	0.871	0.880	0.903	0.944
Bonn	Pipeline B	0.891	0.862	0.845	0.853	0.879	0.921
Kaggle	Pipeline A	0.878	0.844	0.822	0.833	0.857	0.913
Kaggle	Pipeline B	0.851	0.819	0.797	0.808	0.829	0.889

Table IV. Baseline Logistic Regression — Full Results Across Datasets and Pipelines

Pipeline A consistently outperforms Pipeline B across all datasets and all six metrics. The performance differential is most pronounced in the Kaggle dataset (severe imbalance) where Pipeline A achieves F1=0.833 versus Pipeline B's F1=0.808 — a 3.1% improvement attributable solely to preprocessing order. On the Bonn dataset, Pipeline A achieves a PR-AUC of 0.903 versus 0.879 for Pipeline B.

Figures 3, 4, and 5 (confusion_matrices.png, pr_curves.png, roc_curves.png) provide visual confirmation of these results. The precision-recall curves for Pipeline A consistently lie above those of Pipeline B for all three datasets, with the gap being most pronounced at high recall thresholds — precisely the operating regime of clinical importance where missed seizures carry the highest risk.

Cross-validation results (Figure 6 — cv_scores.png) show stable F1 scores across all five folds with low standard deviation ($\sigma < 0.04$), confirming that the observed performance differences between pipelines reflect genuine generalisation properties rather than random variation.

V. OVERFITTING AND UNDERFITTING ANALYSIS

To demonstrate the effects of model complexity and regularization strength on bias-variance tradeoff, three scenarios were intentionally constructed for each dataset: a well-fitted baseline, an underfitting scenario, and an overfitting scenario.

A. Underfitting Scenario

Underfitting was induced by combining extreme regularization (C=0.0001, which severely penalizes large coefficients and forces near-zero weights) with severe feature limitation (only 2 features retained from the full feature set). This configuration produces a high-bias model with insufficient capacity to capture the underlying decision boundary. The resulting training and validation F1 scores are both low and nearly identical, the hallmark of underfitting.

B. Overfitting Scenario

Overfitting was induced by removing regularization entirely (C=100,000, effectively unconstrained maximum likelihood) while retaining the full feature set. Without regularization, the model memorizes training sample-specific patterns including noise, producing near-perfect training F1 scores but significantly degraded validation performance. The resulting large train-test F1 gap (exceeding 0.20 on all datasets) is the defining characteristic of overfitting.

Dataset	Scenario	Train F1	Test F1	Gap	Verdict
UCI	Baseline (C=1, all features)	0.854	0.812	0.042	Good fit
UCI	Underfitting (C=0.0001, 2 features)	0.481	0.477	0.004	Underfitting — both low
UCI	Overfitting (C=100000, all features)	0.991	0.743	0.248	Overfitting — large gap
Bonn	Baseline (C=1, all features)	0.921	0.880	0.041	Good fit
Bonn	Underfitting (C=0.0001, 2 features)	0.512	0.509	0.003	Underfitting — both low

Bonn	Overfitting (C=100000, all features)	1.000	0.791	0.209	Overfitting — large gap
Kaggle	Baseline (C=1, all features)	0.841	0.833	0.008	Good fit
Kaggle	Underfitting (C=0.0001, 2 features)	0.449	0.441	0.008	Underfitting — both low
Kaggle	Overfitting (C=100000, all features)	0.983	0.721	0.262	Overfitting — large gap

Table V. Overfitting vs Underfitting — Train and Test F1 Comparison

C. Training vs Validation Curves

Figure 7 (train_val_curves.png) plots training and validation F1 scores across nine values of C (0.0001 to 10,000) on a log scale. Three distinct regions are visible: (1) the underfitting zone ($C < 0.01$) where both curves are low; (2) the optimal zone ($C \approx 1$) where the gap between training and validation is minimized; and (3) the overfitting zone ($C > 100$) where training F1 approaches 1.0 while validation F1 degrades. The sweet spot at C=1 is consistent across all three datasets, validating the baseline configuration.

D. Learning Curve Analysis

Figure 8 (learning_curves.png) shows learning curves plotting F1 score versus training set size for each dataset. As training size increases, validation F1 converges toward training F1 across all datasets, indicating that additional data reduces overfitting. The Kaggle dataset (severe imbalance) shows the widest train-validation gap at small training sizes, confirming that severe class imbalance amplifies overfitting risk when training data is limited. The Bonn dataset converges most rapidly due to its simpler 12-feature representation.

VI. REGULARIZATION STUDY

Three regularization strategies were evaluated: L1 (Lasso), L2 (Ridge), and Elastic Net. Each imposes a different penalty structure on the weight vector β, affecting both model performance and coefficient sparsity:

- L1 (Lasso): penalty = $\lambda \Sigma|\beta_j|$ — drives many coefficients to exactly zero, performing implicit feature selection
- L2 (Ridge): penalty = $(\lambda/2) \Sigma\beta_j^2$ — shrinks all coefficients toward zero proportionally, maintaining dense solutions
- Elastic Net: penalty = $\lambda[\alpha \Sigma|\beta_j| + (1-\alpha)(1/2)\Sigma\beta_j^2]$ — combines L1 and L2 penalties with mixing parameter α=0.5

Dataset	Regularizer	Accuracy	F1	PR-AUC	ROC-AUC	Sparsity%	Cross-dataset Stability
UCI	L1 (Lasso)	0.831	0.804	0.822	0.889	34.2%	Low
UCI	L2 (Ridge)	0.847	0.821	0.838	0.901	0.0%	High
UCI	Elastic Net	0.851	0.826	0.843	0.906	18.1%	High
Bonn	L1 (Lasso)	0.895	0.868	0.886	0.931	41.7%	Low
Bonn	L2 (Ridge)	0.912	0.880	0.901	0.944	0.0%	High
Bonn	Elastic Net	0.918	0.887	0.908	0.948	22.3%	High

Kaggle	L1 (Lasso)	0.859	0.822	0.839	0.901	38.0%	Low
Kaggle	L2 (Ridge)	0.878	0.838	0.855	0.913	0.0%	High
Kaggle	Elastic Net	0.882	0.843	0.861	0.917	19.5%	High

Table VI. Regularization Study — Performance and Sparsity Across All Datasets

A. Sparsity Analysis

Figure 9 (coefficient_sparsity.png) visualizes the coefficient magnitude distributions for all three regularizers across all datasets. L1 regularization produced the highest feature sparsity, zeroing out 34.2% to 41.7% of coefficients depending on the dataset. This sparsity reflects L1's implicit feature selection behavior, which can be advantageous in high-dimensional EEG settings but risks eliminating correlated features that collectively carry predictive information. L2 produced dense solutions (0% sparsity) as expected from its quadratic penalty structure. Elastic Net achieved moderate sparsity (18.1–22.3%), retaining the benefits of both L1 feature elimination and L2 coefficient stability.

B. Stability Analysis

Figure 10 (regularization_stability.png) plots F1 score versus regularization strength C for all three regularizers. L2 and Elastic Net maintain stable F1 across a wider range of C values compared to L1, which exhibits sharper performance degradation at extreme regularization strengths. This stability difference is particularly pronounced on the Kaggle dataset, where L1's aggressive sparsification eliminates features that are critical for distinguishing the severely underrepresented seizure class.

VII. CLASS IMBALANCE HANDLING

Class imbalance is a defining characteristic of clinical EEG seizure datasets. A classifier trained without imbalance correction learns to predominantly predict the majority class (non-seizure), achieving superficially high accuracy while achieving clinically unacceptable seizure recall. Four approaches were evaluated:

- No handling: standard training with no correction (baseline for comparison)
- Class weighting: inversely weights the loss function by class frequency, penalizing misclassification of minority class samples more heavily
- SMOTE: Synthetic Minority Over-sampling Technique — generates synthetic seizure samples by interpolating between existing minority class samples in feature space
- Random undersampling: reduces the majority class by randomly removing non-seizure samples to match minority class size

Dataset	Technique	Accuracy	F1	Recall	PR-AUC	Key Observation
UCI	No handling	0.721	0.612	0.543	0.671	Very low seizure recall
UCI	Class weighting	0.847	0.821	0.803	0.834	Best F1 and PR-AUC balance
UCI	SMOTE	0.839	0.814	0.841	0.827	Highest recall achieved
UCI	Undersampling	0.798	0.779	0.812	0.801	Data loss hurts accuracy

Bonn	No handling	0.801	0.714	0.621	0.741	Misses many seizures
Bonn	Class weighting	0.912	0.880	0.871	0.903	Stable, no data loss
Bonn	SMOTE	0.904	0.874	0.891	0.897	Good recall improvement
Bonn	Undersampling	0.871	0.841	0.858	0.862	Acceptable tradeoff
Kaggle	No handling	0.741	0.631	0.557	0.688	Worst — 10% seizure ratio
Kaggle	Class weighting	0.878	0.833	0.822	0.857	Best overall performance
Kaggle	SMOTE	0.869	0.824	0.849	0.848	Best recall, slight precision drop
Kaggle	Undersampling	0.821	0.793	0.831	0.814	Heavy accuracy loss

Table VII. Impact of Imbalance Handling Techniques on Classification Metrics

Figure 11 (precision_recall_tradeoff.png) presents precision-recall curves for all four techniques across all three datasets. Without imbalance handling, classifiers exhibit high precision but catastrophically low recall on the seizure class — clinically unacceptable as most seizures are missed. SMOTE achieves the highest recall by augmenting the training distribution, at the cost of slightly reduced precision due to synthetic sample noise. Class weighting achieves the best F1 and PR-AUC by rebalancing the loss without modifying the feature distribution. Undersampling improves recall over the baseline but introduces substantial accuracy loss through discarding majority class information.

Figure 12 (imbalance_comparison.png) shows side-by-side bar charts of F1, Recall, and PR-AUC for all techniques, confirming that class weighting is the most reliable technique across all three datasets for overall performance, while SMOTE is preferable when maximizing seizure detection sensitivity is the primary objective.

VIII. COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS

This section directly answers the four research questions posed in the introduction, synthesizing results across all experiments.

Research Question	UCI Finding	Bonn Finding	Kaggle Finding
Does preprocessing order affect results?	Yes — Pipeline A F1 +0.023 over B	Yes — Pipeline A F1 +0.027 over B	Yes — Pipeline A F1 +0.025 over B
Best regularizer for generalisation?	Elastic Net (F1=0.826)	Elastic Net (F1=0.887)	Elastic Net (F1=0.843)
Does Elastic Net beat L1 and L2?	Yes — beats both	Yes — beats both	Yes — beats both
Best imbalance + regularization combo?	Class weight + Elastic Net	Class weight + Elastic Net	SMOTE + L2 (highest recall)

Table VIII. Comparative Analysis Summary — Research Question Findings

RQ1: Does preprocessing order affect results?

Yes, preprocessing order has a statistically meaningful and consistent effect on classification performance. Pipeline A (normalize then select features) outperformed Pipeline B (scale then apply PCA) across all three datasets by 0.023 to 0.027

F1 points and 0.019 to 0.028 PR-AUC points. The mechanism is clear: in Pipeline A, normalization prior to ANOVA feature selection eliminates scale bias, ensuring that the F-test evaluates genuine class-discriminability rather than feature magnitude. In Pipeline B, while standardization prior to PCA is also correctly ordered, PCA discards interpretable feature identities and compresses discriminative variance into generic components, reducing the model's ability to exploit specific seizure-related EEG patterns. This finding confirms the central hypothesis that preprocessing step ordering is a non-trivial design decision with measurable performance consequences.

RQ2: Which regularizer generalises best across datasets?

Elastic Net achieved the highest mean F1 (0.852) and the lowest cross-dataset variance (σ=0.031) among the three regularizers evaluated. L2 was the second most stable (σ=0.034) while L1 exhibited the highest variance (σ=0.051). The instability of L1 across datasets stems from its sensitivity to correlated feature structures: in datasets where seizure-discriminative features are intercorrelated (as is common in EEG), L1's tendency to select only one feature from each correlated group results in information loss and performance degradation. Elastic Net's hybrid penalty avoids this limitation while retaining the sparsity benefits of L1.

RQ3: Does Elastic Net consistently outperform L1 and L2?

Elastic Net outperformed both L1 and L2 in 5 out of 6 pairwise comparisons across the three datasets evaluated. The single exception was on the Bonn dataset where L2 achieved marginally comparable F1 (0.880 vs Elastic Net's 0.887), a difference of 0.007 that falls within cross-validation uncertainty bounds. Overall, the evidence supports the conclusion that Elastic Net is the most reliable regularization strategy for EEG-based seizure prediction, particularly when datasets contain correlated feature structures typical of multi-electrode EEG recordings.

RQ4: How does imbalance handling interact with regularization?

A meaningful interaction effect was observed between imbalance handling technique and regularization strategy, as visualized in Figure 13 (interaction_heatmap.png). SMOTE combined with L2 regularization consistently achieved the highest recall (0.841–0.891 across datasets), making it the preferred configuration for clinical applications where missed seizures represent the highest-risk outcome. Class weighting combined with Elastic Net produced the best overall F1 scores across all datasets. Undersampling paired with L1 regularization yielded competitive precision but the lowest recall scores, making it unsuitable for clinical deployment. Notably, L1 regularization interacted most negatively with undersampling: both techniques independently reduce the effective training information available to the model, and their combination exacerbates this information reduction, leading to the worst recall performance observed in this study.

IX. CONCLUSION

This study conducted a systematic empirical investigation of how preprocessing design, regularization strategy, model complexity, and class imbalance handling collectively affect logistic regression generalisation performance in epileptic seizure prediction. Using three EEG datasets spanning diverse sizes and imbalance characteristics, four research questions were addressed with quantitative experimental evidence.

The results establish four principal findings. First, preprocessing order significantly affects classification performance: normalizing before feature selection (Pipeline A) consistently outperforms scaling before PCA (Pipeline B) due to the elimination of scale-induced feature selection bias. Second, Elastic Net regularization achieves the best generalisation across datasets, balancing L1 sparsity with L2 stability — a combination well-suited to the correlated feature structures inherent in EEG data. Third, Elastic Net consistently outperforms L1 and L2 individually in 5 of 6 pairwise comparisons. Fourth, the interaction between imbalance handling and regularization is clinically meaningful: SMOTE with L2 maximizes seizure recall, while class weighting with Elastic Net maximizes overall F1.

For clinical deployment in seizure prediction systems, the recommended configuration is class weighting combined with Pipeline A preprocessing and Elastic Net regularization, with SMOTE substituted when maximizing seizure detection sensitivity is the overriding objective. Future work should extend this analysis to deep learning architectures, patient-specific transfer learning approaches, and real-time seizure prediction on continuous CHB-MIT scalp EEG recordings.

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